

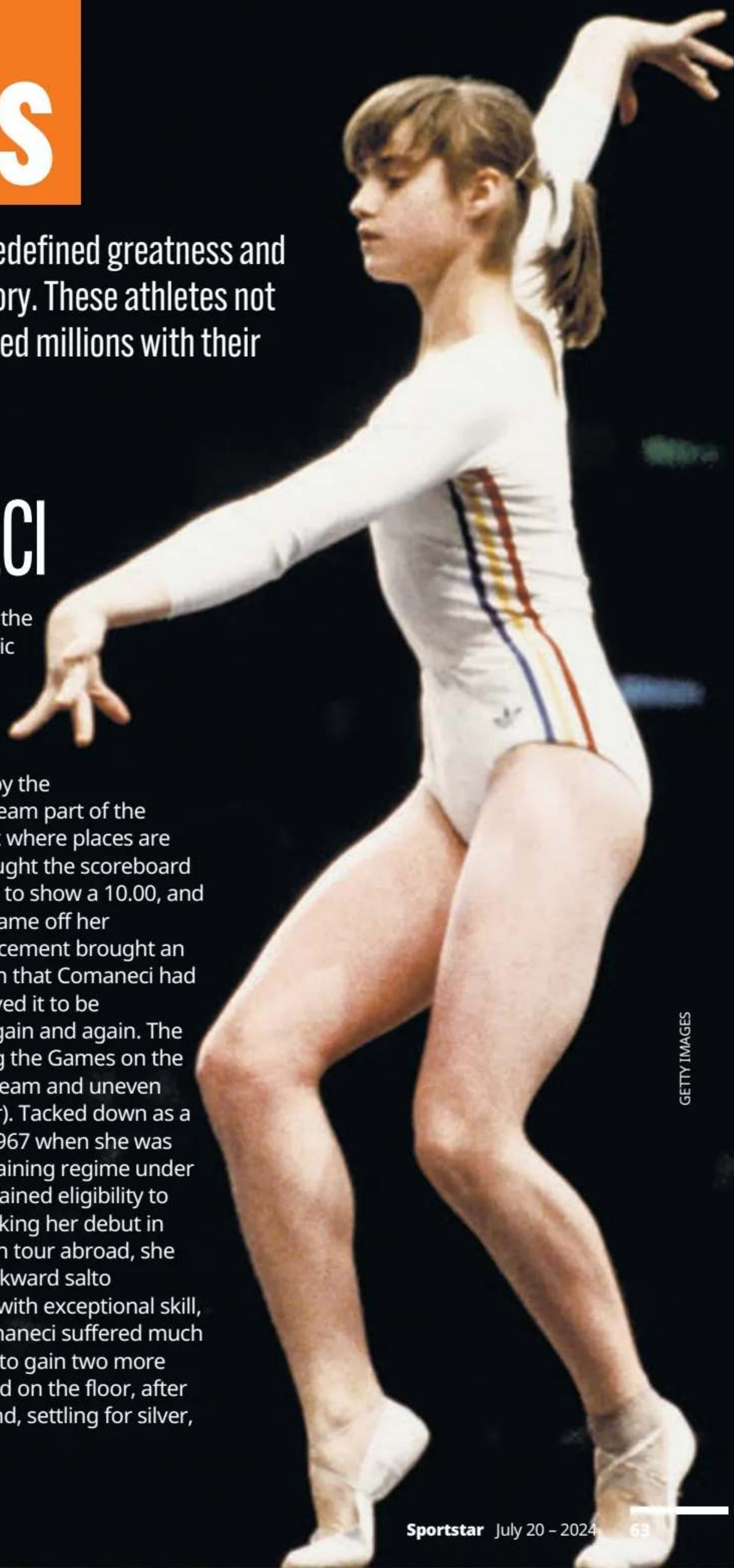
GOLDEN MEMORIES

Meet five Olympic champions who redefined greatness and left an indelible mark on sports history. These athletes not only **clinched gold** but also inspired millions with their incredible feats.

Team Sportstar

NADIA COMANECI

The world was quite unprepared for the arrival of Nadia Comaneci at the Olympic stage. What could a man-made scoreboard do under such circumstances but blink? Montreal 1976 will always be known for this faux pas as well as the perfect 10 turned in by the 14-year-old Romanian gymnast in the team part of the competition for the first time. In a sport where places are determined by fractions, none had thought the scoreboard would be required to display four digits to show a 10.00, and in the end what Comaneci saw as she came off her dismount was 1.00. The official announcement brought an end to the drama as it was made known that Comaneci had achieved perfection. Once she had proved it to be achievable, she couldn't stop doing it again and again. The Romanian, in fact, carded six 10s during the Games on the way to three gold medals (all-around, beam and uneven bars), a silver (team) and a bronze (floor). Tacked down as a long-term prospect by Bela Karolyi in 1967 when she was just six, Comaneci underwent a strict training regime under the future Romanian chief coach. She gained eligibility to compete at the senior level in 1975, making her debut in America for the first time on her maiden tour abroad, she left an indelible mark with a double backward salto dismount off the uneven bars. Blessed with exceptional skill, balance and impressive technique, Comaneci suffered much due to an injury before she rebounded to gain two more golds at Moscow 1980, off the beam and on the floor, after she fell behind narrowly in the all-around, settling for silver, by a 0.1-point margin.



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